Ela Bhatt was born in Ahmedabad. While working with the Textile Labour Association (TLA), one of the oldest labour unions in India, she learned of the difficulties faced by female informal workers, who did gruelling jobs for low pay with no job security. In 1972, Bhatt founded the Self-Employed Women's Association (SEWA) to help these workers demand better conditions and pay. Since then, SEWA has expanded to aid women in over a hundred other sectors, offering small loans for its members to start businesses; setting up cooperatives and benefit schemes, and helping its members share skills and knowledge. Bhatt has won awards and for her work with the Indian government and international organizations on issues such as poverty, safeguarding street vendors' livelihoods and encouraging women's self-employment and financial independence.



Ela Bhatt inspecting the handicrafts produced by the Kalandia Camp Women's Handicraft Cooperative, which was formed by nine Palestinian women.

MABELLE AROLE

1935–1999